GRAMMY'S

Allie Book

A STORYBOOK TO KEEP & SHARE



A KEEPSAKE STORYBOOK

GRAMMY'S ALLIE BOOK

RAMBLEBOOK

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ABOUT THIS DRAFT

Grammy's Allie Book is a working draft, produced with RambleBook from an original story idea. It is complete as a story — beginning, middle, and end, in 6 chapters — and deliberately unfinished as a book. Chapter One is written at full weight; the chapters that follow are leaner, the way first drafts are: the bones and the heartbeat, waiting for a writer's second pass. Writing is rewriting. This is the draft you rewrite from.

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Chapter 1

The Cardboard Rocket

In Grammy's garden, behind the tomato plants and the rose bush that scratched anybody who got fresh with it, there stood a rocket.

It was made of cardboard. It was held together with tape, hope, and one of Grammy's good bedsheets, which Grammy pretended not to recognize. And it belonged, entirely and officially, to Allie — who was 7 years old, and silly, and determined, and curious all the way through, like the letters in a stick of rock candy.

"Grammy!" called Allie, from the top of a step stool, which was Mission Control. "The rocket is ready. The moon is ready. Are YOU ready?"

Grammy looked up from the garden. She was holding a wooden spoon, because she had been stirring something, but Allie knew the truth about

that spoon. Everybody in the family knew. It was not really a spoon.

It was a wand that had retired and taken up cooking.

"Ready," said Grammy, and she hung the spoon from her belt like a sword. "But a launch takes courage. Do we have courage?"

"We have courage," said Allie. "We have courage, we have snacks, and we have—" Allie reached into the rocket and held up a small, serious passenger. "—we have Captain Buttons, his one-eyed teddy bear."

"Then we have everything," said Grammy. "Climb aboard, Captain."

Chapter 2

The Night Grammy Said Yes

Most grown-ups say, “It’s nearly bedtime.” Most grown-ups say, “Rockets are for tomorrow.”

But Grammy remembered something important. She remembered the day — the famous day — when he hid inside the laundry basket and jumped out at the cat. She had laughed so hard that day that her tea came out of her nose, which Allie still described as “the funniest emergency ever.”

A kid who can cause a tea emergency, Grammy figured, can be trusted with the moon.

So as the first stars came out, Grammy checked the rocket’s tape. She checked the snacks twice, because snacks are the part of space travel that scientists take most seriously. Then she did the thing she always did before anything big: she pointed her spoon at the sky and whispered the words every

grandma knows and no book has ever printed — until now.

They are very secret. They rhyme with “moon.” That is all you get.

The garden lights flickered. The tomato plants stood up straighter. And the cardboard rocket, very quietly, cleared its throat.

Chapter 3

The Moon Is Made of Pancakes

Here is what the astronauts never tell you: the moon smells wonderful, and that is because the moon is made, almost entirely, of pancakes.

Allie took the first step onto the Sea of Tranquility and it went squish in the nicest possible way. "Grammy," Allie whispered, "we have to tell everybody."

"We tell nobody," said Grammy, already spreading the picnic blanket. "Some things are just for us."

They ate pancakes on the moon, with the whole Earth hanging in the sky like a blue marble somebody loved very much. And Allie did the thing Allie always does, right there on the moon, because a quirk is a quirk and it does not care about gravity: giggley.

"Allie," said Grammy, "when you're very old, you'll forget some things. Try to remember this picnic."

“I’ll remember,” said Allie. “I’ll remember because it’s OURS.”

Chapter 4

The Great Space Race

Trouble in space never looks like trouble. Ours looked like a game.

A sleepy little comet — no bigger than a teapot, and twice as lost — came wobbling past the picnic blanket, crying tiny sparks. It had lost the race. It had lost the other comets. It had, in fact, lost everything except speed.

"We have to help," said Allie, "and I know exactly how."

Because Allie knew a game. Not a screen game or a board game — a Allie game, the famous one: pirates in the bathtub. And here is the secret about the famous games of 7-year-olds: if you play them at full power, with your whole heart, they work anywhere. Even in orbit. Especially in orbit.

Allie played. Grammy played. Captain Buttons, his one-eyed teddy bear supervised from the rocket window, looking extremely official.

The little comet laughed so hard it found its sparkle again — and a found sparkle, in space, is the same thing as a found road home.

Chapter 5

Almost Home

Coming home is the hardest part of any adventure. The rocket was tired. The tape was tired. Halfway down through the dark, Allie felt the wobble that every captain dreads, and for one whole second, Allie was scared.

Just one second. Then Allie remembered being silly. Remembered being determined — yes, even that; silly is a kind of engine. And remembered being curious, which is the strongest one of all, and held the little comet's light steady in both hands until the wobble passed.

Below them, a garden was waking up. One window was lit. And in the window, waving both arms like a lighthouse that had won the lottery, was the person Allie would cross any sky to get back to.

"Grammy," said Allie, sleepy as a bear in November, "we made it home before bedtime."

“We made it home,” said Grammy, “before the end of bedtime. There’s a difference. Captains know it.”

Chapter 6

Grammy's Shelf

The rocket lives in the garden still. The tape is new. The sheet has been washed, ironed, and returned to the linen closet under circumstances nobody discusses.

But the important thing — the thing this whole book was made to tell you — is on a shelf.

If you go to Grammy's house, and you look on Grammy's very best shelf, between the photographs and the mug that says WORLD'S OKAYEST GARDENER (a title Grammy defends fiercely), you will find this book. This one. The one you are holding.

It stays there because Grammy shows it to people. She shows it to the neighbors. She shows it to the book club, and the postman, and once to a man who only came to read the meter. And whenever Allie visits, she takes it down, and they read it together, and the moon is made of pancakes all over again.

Some books are for reading.
This one is for keeping.
For Grammy — with love, always, Steve Smythe
The End

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

RambleBook makes storybooks about the people you love, for the people who keep them.

A storybook to keep & share

Allie is 7 years old — silly, determined, and curious all the way through. In this story, Allie and Grammy fly a cardboard rocket to a moon made of pancakes. A keepsake storybook about Allie, made for Grammy to keep, to show, and to read aloud.